

MCKINSEY GLOBAL INSTITUTE · 2025

The \$2.9 Trillion Miscalculation

Why Most Companies Investing in AI
Are Capturing Almost None of It

90% Invested in AI. Fewer Than 40% See Measurable Returns.

The Gap Is Not the Technology. It Is the
Operating Model.

McKinsey analyzed 190 business workflows across
the US economy.

\$2.9T

Economic Value
Available by 2030

90%

Companies That
Say They Have
Invested

<40%

Report Measurable
Gains

Automating Tasks

A feature request.
Incremental efficiency
on top of existing
processes.

Redesigning Workflows

A competitive
position. The
difference
between
capturing value
and watching
others do it.



\$1.7 Trillion Sits in Sector-Specific Operations. Not in the Back Office.

60% of AI's Total Value Comes from the Core of Your Industry. The Rest from Cross-Cutting Functions.

McKinsey mapped \$2.9 trillion in economic value across 190 workflows.

\$1.7 Trillion, Sector-Specific Domains

- Supply chain
- Manufacturing operations
- Clinical diagnosis
- Risk and compliance

\$1.2 Trillion, Cross-Cutting Functions

- IT
- Finance
- HR
- Administrative services

77% of that total comes from AI agents. Not robots.

Healthcare
\$351 billion

Professional
Services
\$323 billion

Manufacturing
\$250 billion

❏ If your AI investments are concentrated in back-office automation, you are competing for the smaller share of the value table. The bulk requires redesigning how your core operations run.

Three Companies Redesigned Workflows. Three Sets of Hard Numbers Followed.

In Every Case, People Did Not Disappear. They Moved to Higher-Value Work.

Global Tech Company — Sales Workflow

AI agents handled lead scoring and outreach. Sales specialists redirected **30 to 50% of time** to negotiation. Projected revenue increase: **7 to 12%**.

Global Pharma Company — Clinical Reporting

AI agents drafted study reports. Time to first human-reviewed draft fell **nearly 60%**. Errors declined **approximately 50%**.

Large Utility — 7 Million Annual Support Calls

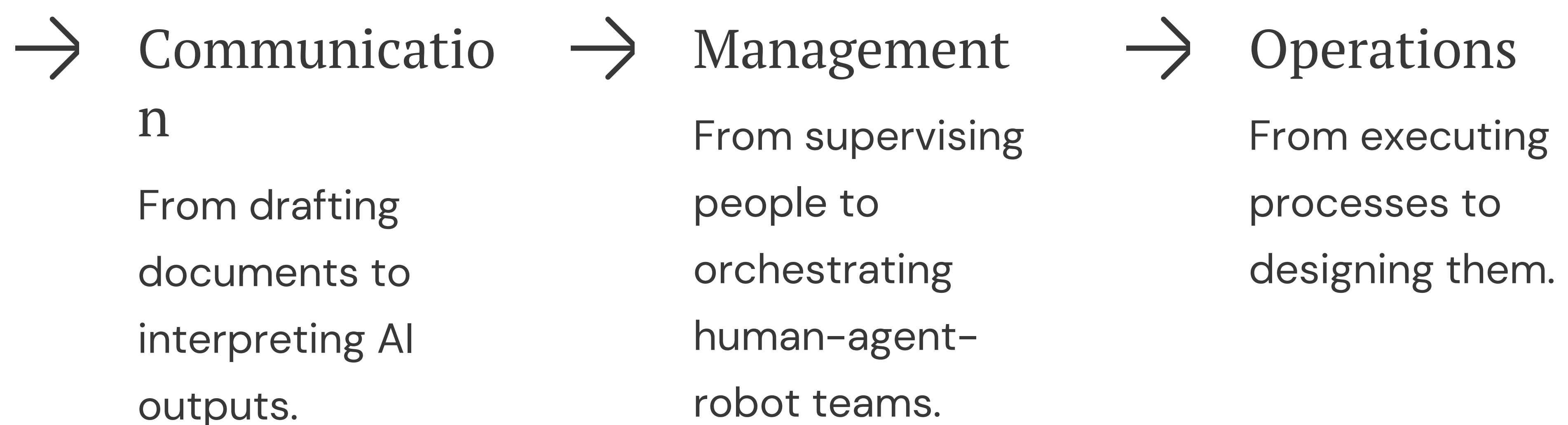
AI agents now resolve **40% of calls** without human involvement. Cost per call cut **roughly 50%**. Customer satisfaction up **6 percentage points**.

In each case, the CEO owned the redesign. Not IT. Not a task force. The executive team.

72% of Today's Skills Apply to Both Automated and Non-Automated Work.

Your Workforce Is Not Becoming Obsolete. Their Roles Are Being Rewritten.

McKinsey analyzed 6,800 skills across 11 million US job postings. **72% of those skills are needed in both automatable and non-automatable tasks.** What changes is not whether skills matter. It is how and where they are applied.



The technology could theoretically touch **57% of US work hours today**. But electricity took 30+ years to spread. Cloud computing, available since the mid-2000s, was used by only 1 in 5 companies in 2023.

❏ The bottleneck is never the technology. It is always the speed of organizational redesign.

Your Competitor's Operations Team Will Be AI-Fluent in 18 Months. Will Yours?

AI Fluency Demand Grew 7x in Two Years. Faster Than Any Prior Skill Category.

1M

US Workers
Requiring AI Fluency
2023

7M

US Workers
Requiring AI Fluency
Mid-2025

600+

New Skills in Job
Postings in Just Two
Years

7x in 24 months. Faster than cloud. Faster than cybersecurity. Faster than any digital skill wave before it. Nearly 600 new skills appeared in job postings in just two years — that is one-third of all new skills added across the entire past decade.

75% of AI Skill Demand Is Concentrated In:

- Computing
- Management
- Business & Finance

Rising Demand Also Spreading To:

- Installation & maintenance
- Architecture & engineering
- Education

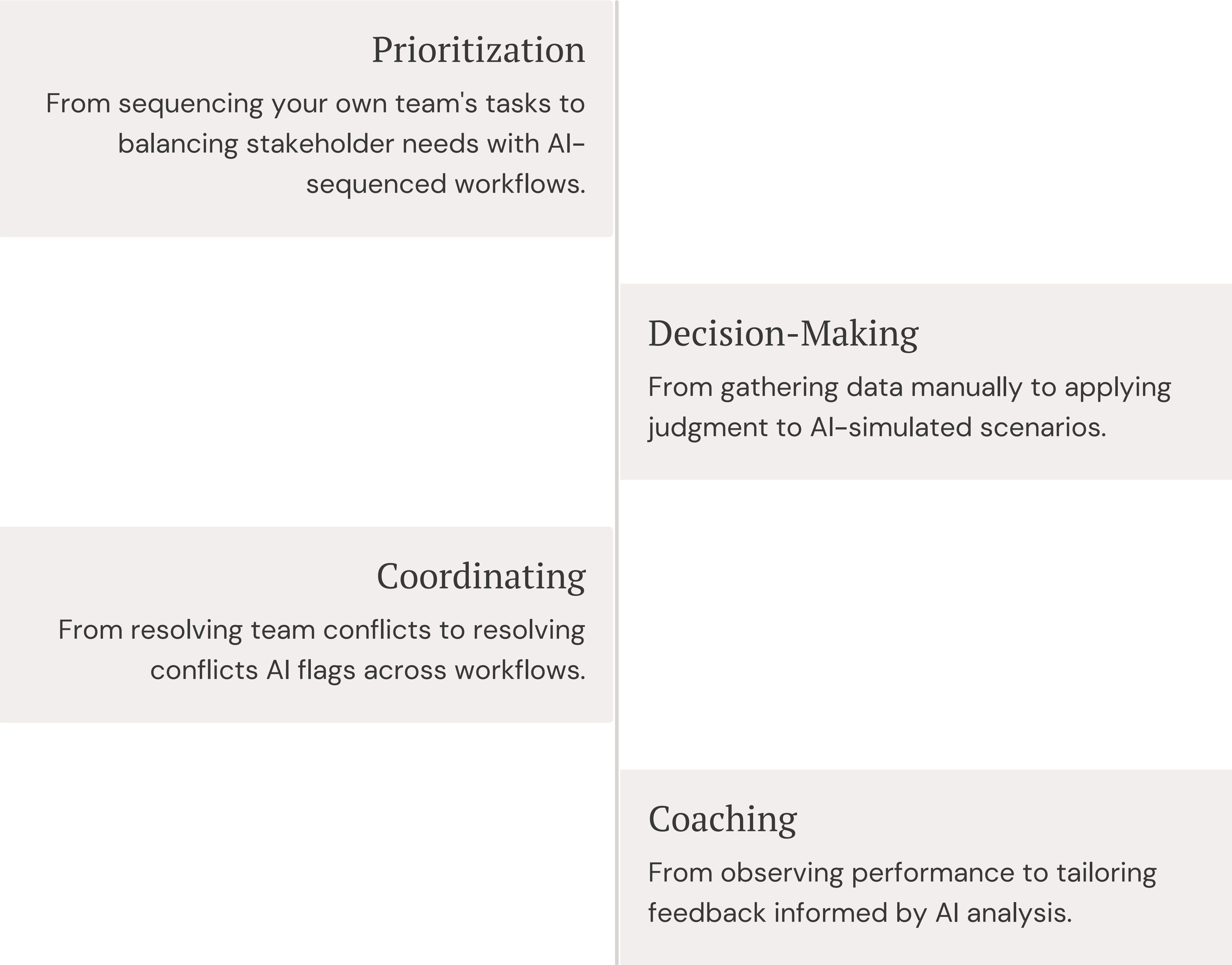
The most durable human skills: **coaching, leadership, mentorship, care**. These sit at the bottom of the automation exposure index. They will endure.

The organizations building AI fluency from the plant floor to the boardroom now will not wait for the talent gap to close. They will create it for their competitors.

Managerial Work Is Not Shrinking. It Is Being Rebuilt from the Inside.

Routine Supervision Gets Absorbed. Coaching, Influence, and Orchestration Rise.

As AI handles more analytical and decision-support tasks, the nature of management shifts.



The manager of 2028 oversees a hybrid workforce: people, agents, and robots.

77% of companies say they intend to upskill. Follow-through is low. Workers often leave after gaining new skills.

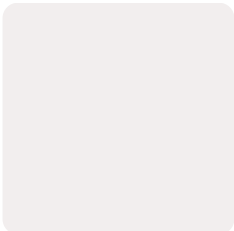
❏ The structural solution: build AI capability into roles and processes. Not into individuals who can walk out the door.

The CEO Who Delegates AI to IT Will Lose This Decade to the One Who Does Not.

Every Company That Captured Returns Had One Thing in Common: Executive Ownership.

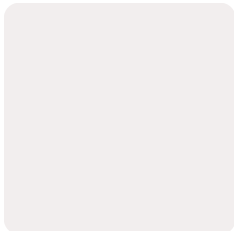
Across every case McKinsey studied, the companies gaining measurable returns shared the same trait. Senior leadership did not treat AI as a technology project. They treated it as a redesign of how the business operates.

That required one hard commitment:



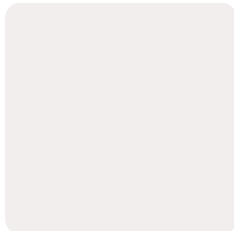
Redesign workflows from scratch.

Not on top of legacy processes.



Invest in skills alongside the technology.

Not as a year-two initiative.



Measure human and machine contributions together.

Not in separate dashboards that produce separate accountability.



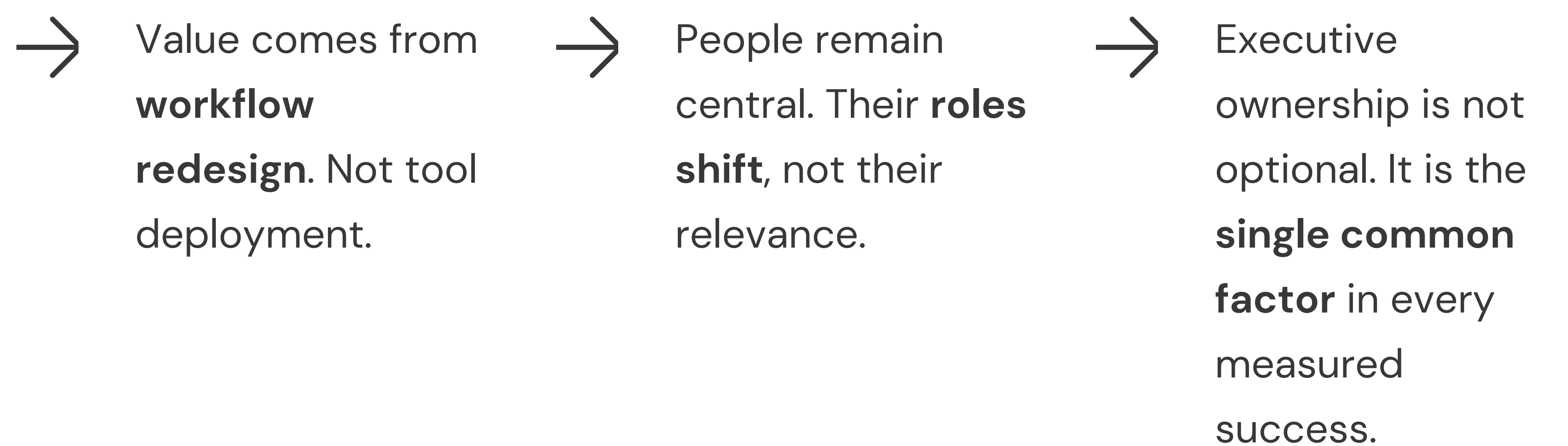
Lasting advantage will not come from which vendor you selected. It will come from how deeply you changed the way work gets done.

The Data Is Clear. The Window Is Open. The Decision Is Yours.

One Question Worth Asking Before Your Next Board Meeting.

\$2.9T	190	6,800	80
In Value by 2030	Mapped Workflows	Analyzed Skills	Implementatio n Cases Studied

The pattern is consistent:



📌 Here is the question:

How many of your 2026 budget lines are tied to redesigning workflows vs. buying more tools?

If you cannot answer that, this post is worth saving.

Source: McKinsey Global Institute, "Agents, Robots, and Us: Skill Partnerships in the Age of AI," November 2025. All data and statistics cited in this carousel are drawn exclusively from this report.